▶ **TSHERING TOBGAY,** *Prime Minister, Bhutan*

QUEST FOR HARMONY

Close your eyes and imagine you are a king.... You love your people, but what's more, your people love you." Thus began the enthralling address of the two-time prime minister of the kingdom of Bhutan, Dasho Tshering Tobgay. Of all the humdrum measurements of economic success that rule the world, that of Bhutan stands out. It was the first country to introduce Gross National Happiness (GNH) to measure economic growth. Tobgay, in a series of hypothetical questions to the audience at the India Today Conclave, elaborated on its continuing relevance. Does the king support free healthcare and education, preserve his land's unique culture, traditions and pristine environment? Build a sustainable economy and not just be "driven mercilessly by market forces"?



KEY TAKEAWAYS

- The first country to introduce the concept of Gross National Happiness, Bhutan is now ready with GNH 2.0
- The cornerstone of this is Gelephu, 'the mindfulness city', an economic hub connecting South and Southeast Asia
- Surrounded by biodiversity hotspots, Gelephu will be the world's first carbon-negative city with low-rise, green buildings

BHUTAN'S JOURNEY HAS BEEN BY AND LARGE SUCCESSFUL BECAUSE OF THE FRIENDSHIP, GOODWILL AND UNCONDITIONAL SUPPORT OF THE GOVERNMENT AND PEOPLE OF INDIA

You can support Bhutan by visiting it as tourists, as guests, as friends. If you visit now, it's springtime. You see flowers blossoming everywhere.... Come in the summer, fall or winter. But do come, make time

GELEPHU IS NOT JUST AN EXPERIMENT IN URBAN DESIGN, BUT A JOURNEY OF GROSS NATIONAL HAPPINESS TO GNH 2.0 FOR THE 21ST CENTURY... A GIFT TO BHUTAN AND ITS FUTURE, BUT ALSO A GIFT TO INDIA AND THE WORLD

Would such a "benevolent dictator" choose to introduce democracy for the people? This, said Tobgay with a gleam in his eyes, is the story of Bhutan and the ideals and principles its kings introduced. Thanking India and its people for its support in making Bhutan's journey successful, Tobgay spelled out the challenges his country faces—of a weak economy hit hard by the pandemic.

To visualise GNH 2.0, Tobgay painted an enticing picture of Gelephu, the mindfulness city, as envisioned by King Khesar Namgyel Wangchuk. It will be an economic hub for sustainable development connecting South and Southeast Asia. Flanked by the rivers Manas and Sunkoshi, and surrounded by protected biodiversity hotspots teeming with wildlife, Gelephu will be the world's first carbon-negative city, enabling people to live in the lap of nature while also "allowing innovation and knowledge to blossom in harmony with sustainability and spirituality". This, said Tobgay, was GNH 2.0 for the 21st century. ■